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If you love the ocean, come to Kai Motion!

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Group #4

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1. Executive Summary

Kai Motion is an ocean school located in Hawai‘i that teaches individuals how to be safe, knowledgeable, and respectful towards the ocean via academic surf trips. The firm incorporates surf lessons, ocean safety, Hawaiian culture education, ocean conservation, and small group settings into one package. While a typical surf school instructs clients how to stand on their surfboards, Kai Motion offers a unique ocean journey that is centered on confidence, mālama, kuleana, and appropriate ocean usage.

The major issue that Kai Motion is seeking to solve is that many ocean adventure firms in Hawaii operate in such a way that they only emphasize the quantity of tourists, convenience, and skills learning. However, this leaves some room for tourists seeking genuine, safe, and culturally respectful ocean activities. As tourism and ocean recreation grow, Hawai‘i also faces pressure from overcrowding, ocean and beach pollution, environmental degradation, and the commercialization of Hawaiian culture.

The beachhead market for Kai Motion is the culturally interested O‘ahu visitor looking for something beyond a basic surfing class for tourists. The reason why this is a desirable beachhead market to start with is that O‘ahu had a total of 5,679,047 tourists in 2025, generating \$9.42 billion in tourism revenue.¹ Assuming a conservative estimate of 2% of O‘ahu visitors falling into Kai Motion’s target market and a conservative \$110 price per lesson, Kai Motion’s TAM is approximately \$12.49 million annually.²

As an attractive, durable, timely, value-adding, and feasible opportunity, Kai Motion presents itself as an interesting one as it meets all the criteria of an opportunity. Low cost of start-up, services provided, customer accessibility, and sustainability of mission are some key features of the organization that make it feasible. Financially speaking, Kai Motion is set up to be a lean firm, with annual revenue

¹ Department of Business, Economic Development and Tourism. (2026, January 29). *Visitor spending increased in December 2025 as visitor arrivals declined*. <https://dbedt.hawaii.gov/blog/26-04>

² TAM calculation based on 5,679,047 O‘ahu visitors × 2% likely target fit × \$110 average revenue per lesson. Visitor count from DBEDT. Average lesson price based on Waikīkī surf lesson comparables from Moniz Family Surf, Hans Hedemann Surf School, and Faith Surf School.

expected to be \$39,000 and net profit after Year 1 to be \$13,740. In year 6, the ending cash balance will be \$86,540. Please see Appendix F for the payback and cash flow statement.

2. The Problem

However, the ocean recreational business in Hawai‘i operates primarily on the principle of volume tourism rather than culture, ecology, and ocean literacy. Surf schools and ocean activity firms tend to process clients efficiently, concentrating on efficiency, fundamental skills training, and transactions. While this method is ideal for visitors seeking quick entertainment, it does not meet the needs of those who desire a secure, genuine, and immersive cultural experience.

There are three main concerns being addressed by Kai Motion that are related to each other, namely: pollution at the beaches and oceans, insufficient awareness of ocean safety, and insufficient knowledge about the marine ecosystem. This issue is important since the ocean in Hawaii is not only a tourist site, but an integral part of the culture, ecology, and economy of Hawaii. The ocean activities, if focused exclusively on satisfying the customers’ demand, may end up leaving nothing except positive memories.

As tourism recovers further post Covid-19, these problems may worsen. Increased numbers of tourists typically translate into increased demand for ocean-based recreation, increased congestion, increased beach usage, and increased environmental effects. On the other hand, the tourism market in Hawai‘i has an appetite for conscious and high-spending tourists who are keen on outdoor adventure, local business ventures, and experiential travel.³

However, the gap in the market is not just that tourists require surf lessons, since there are many surf schools that instruct individuals on how to surf. Indeed, Moniz Family Surf, Hans Hedemann Surf School, and Faith Surf School have advertised their services for providing surf lessons in Waikīkī online.

³ Hawaii Tourism Authority. (n.d.). *Brand marketing*. <https://www.hawaiitourismauthority.org/what-we-do/brand-marketing>

This shows that there is already a market for these lessons. The real issue, which is solved by Kai Motion, is that tourists need more than that, they need to learn about Hawaii.

3. The Solution and Opportunity

Kai Motion takes care of this issue by providing small-group, culturally focused ocean education programs, rather than standard surf lessons for tourists. The organization provides its customers with a unique service, which is called a “scholastic surf adventure” and consists of surfing lessons, ocean safety education, Hawaiian culture education, mālama ‘āina lessons, and individual mentoring.

A Kai Motion class would start before the guests step into the water. The students would be taught basic safety information regarding the ocean environment, how to interpret the environment, pick up just a few pieces of trash to give back to the environment, currents, proper lineup etiquette, and responsible behavior when interacting with others in the ocean. The next stage would involve learning about the basic skills for surfing in small groups. In addition, culture-based stories and stewardship projects, like cleaning the beach, would be included. The launch process for building this experience, testing it, and moving into paid lessons is outlined in [Appendix A](#).

This model not only gives the client practical benefits but also psychological benefits. Practical benefits include confidence in the ocean, knowledge regarding safety, and knowledge regarding proper behavior in the ocean. Psychological benefits include increased satisfaction as they get to learn more about Hawaii while engaging in an important activity on and for the island.

Why is Kai Motion a compelling proposition? First, Kai Motion will be a service-oriented firm requiring very little start-up capital, which has already been acquired due to personal funding and the University of Hawai'i Kalo Grant presented by PACE, as shown in [Appendix G](#). Kai Motion also presents opportunities for large margins, alongside a target market that is accessible. The beachhead customer is accessible due to the concentration of tourist demand in Waikīkī, and the fact that surf schools are already

utilizing online means to attract tourists.⁴ Kai Motion is also timely and durable because surfing, as an activity, is not a passing trend. It is valuable because it adds value to the customer, the local surf instructor, and the environment. Lastly, Kai Motion boasts an edge due to its team and ohana-style nature.

4. Beachhead Market

The cultural beachhead for Kai Motion is curious in the case of Oahu tourists who are looking to enjoy a real surfing experience and water activities. In case of looking for beachhead markets, selecting one target customer base is crucial before proceeding further, since the enterprise may ultimately cater to the following customers: tourists, students, keiki, locals, families, and corporations.

Kai Motion had two potential beachhead customers to target, who were: Oahu visitors interested in their culture and UH Manoa students looking for a culture-rich yet easy ocean experience. The latter would be perfect, while the former would make an excellent choice, as these people have access to finances and will not mind paying for lessons. Moreover, these people have already spent money on their travel adventures that are often outdoors and cultural. However, students can still be targeted in the future. The analysis of students is provided in [Appendix C](#).

The target beachhead customer consists of tourists who visit O‘ahu and usually reside in or around Waikīkī, with interests in beach recreation, outdoor adventures, Hawaiian culture, and significant travel experiences. It should be noted that the selected customer does not only desire to have the least expensive surfing lesson.

Applying the six beachhead questions, this section scores highly. Firstly, the customer has sufficient money. In 2025, the island of O‘ahu hosted 5,679,047 tourists who spent \$9.42 billion.⁵

⁴ Moniz Family Surf. (n.d.). *Surf lessons*. <https://www.monizfamilysurf.com/surfing/surf-lessons/>; Hans Hedemann Surf School. (n.d.). *Surf lessons Waikiki | Learn to surf*. <https://hhsurf.com/>; Faith Surf School. (n.d.). *Waikiki surf lessons*. <https://faithsurfschool.com/surf-lessons>

⁵ Department of Business, Economic Development and Tourism. (2026, January 29). *Visitor spending increased in December 2025 as visitor arrivals declined*. <https://dbedt.hawaii.gov/blog/26-04>

Tourism planning for the state of Hawaii focuses on eco-conscious travelers who invest in outdoor pursuits, small businesses, and unique experiences.⁶ Secondly, the customer is accessible as tourists congregate at Waikīkī, and current surf schools connect to tourists through websites, online booking, hotel recommendations, and tourism networks.

Consequently, there is no doubt that the customer will be motivated to purchase because Kai Motion provides more than a typical surf lesson. The lessons incorporate surfing, ocean safety, culture, storytelling, and mālama ‘āina. Fourth, there is competition in the area because other Waikīkī surf schools have established brands, and their group prices range between \$95 and \$125.⁷ However, Kai Motion can use differentiation through its smaller groups, stewardship, storytelling, and culture lessons to distinguish itself from competitors. Fifth, establishing a beachhead at Waikīkī Beach will open doors for collaboration with hotels, families, return visitors, keiki, students from the University of Hawai‘i at Mānoa, locals, and companies. Sixth, the chosen market fits with Kai Motion’s philosophy.

Maya Chen, aged 28 years, hails from Seattle and visits Hawaii for a five-day vacation tour. Maya wants to engage in an activity involving the ocean, but she is not interested in a shallow, educational tour that has nothing to do with the culture of Hawaii. Maya will be prepared to pay around \$100-\$130 for a premium small group tour if she feels it is authentic, safe, and respectful. Logically, Maya will look for factors like quality, safety, and value. Also, Maya seeks an emotional connection with Hawaii that stands out from other experiences.

Kai Motion’s TAM for this beachhead comes out to be about \$12.49 million per year: 5,679,047 tourists to O‘ahu × 2% target market fit × \$110 per lesson.⁸ The above figure is quite conservative since

⁶ Hawaii Tourism Authority. (n.d.). *Brand marketing*. <https://www.hawaiitourismauthority.org/what-we-do/brand-marketing>

⁷ Moniz Family Surf. (n.d.). *Surf lessons*. <https://www.monizfamilysurf.com/surfing/surf-lessons/>; Hans Hedemann Surf School. (n.d.). *Surf lessons Waikiki | Learn to surf*. <https://hhsurf.com/>; Faith Surf School. (n.d.). *Waikiki surf lessons*. <https://faithsurfschool.com/surf-lessons>

⁸ TAM calculation based on 5,679,047 O‘ahu visitors × 2% likely target fit × \$110 average revenue per lesson. Visitor count from DBEDT. Average lesson price based on Waikīkī surf lesson comparables from Moniz Family Surf, Hans Hedemann Surf School, and Faith Surf School. Department of Business, Economic Development and Tourism. (2026, January 29). *Visitor spending increased in December 2025*

not all the tourists will be interested in taking surfing or ocean lessons. The full visitor beachhead TAM calculation is shown in [Appendix B](#).

It should be noted that Kai Motion did not target UH Mānoa students for its beachhead entry, although it will make a powerful market in the future. However, despite their accessibility and alignment with the company's mission, they are less funded and probably need to buy products at a discount. The UH Mānoa campus had 20,404 students in Fall 2025, with an expected TAM of $20,404 \text{ students} \times 8\%$ probable interest $\times \$150 \text{ per student} = \text{about } \$244,848 \text{ yearly}$.⁹

5. Identity

The identity of Kai Motion is created based on being the ocean school that trains the safest, most competent, and most respectful ocean users. The mission of the business is to train the watermen and waterwomen who know Hawaiian culture, the safety of the ocean, and the underwater environment. Profitability of the business is not calculated in terms of sales, but in terms of creating awareness among the clients in the community of the island.

To fulfill its identity, Kai Motion requires staff who will not only be able to instruct people how to surf but also have expertise in the ocean as well as knowledge of safety in the ocean. They should have CPR and first aid certification, know about the local culture, have a talent for storytelling, customer service skills, and good operating systems.

as visitor arrivals declined. <https://dbedt.hawaii.gov/blog/26-04/>; Moniz Family Surf. (n.d.). *Surf lessons*. <https://www.monizfamilysurf.com/surfing/surf-lessons/>; Hans Hedemann Surf School. (n.d.). *Surf lessons Waikiki | Learn to surf*. <https://hhsurf.com/>; Faith Surf School. (n.d.). *Waikiki surf lessons*. <https://faithsurfschool.com/surf-lessons>

⁹ University of Hawai'i System News. (2025, October 5). *UH enrollment tops 51,000, highest in eight years*. <https://www.hawaii.edu/news/2025/10/05/uh-enrollment-tops-51000-highest-in-eight-years/>; University of Hawai'i at Mānoa Student Life & Development. (n.d.). *Outdoor classes*. <https://manoa.hawaii.edu/studentlife/recreation/outdoor-edventure/outdoor-classes/>; University of Hawai'i System News. (2020, May 10). *UH students surf, learn culture, earn academic credit*. <https://www.hawaii.edu/news/2020/05/10/masterson-polynesian-surf-culture>

Kai Motion should cultivate a reputation as the ocean experience company that does ocean activities properly. This involves developing a reputation for doing things with small groups, using local guides, demonstrating environmental stewardship, having cultural context, and always maintaining ocean safety. Kai Motion must ensure that responsible behavior is integrated into the guest experience. For example, Kai Motion could require guests to participate in a beach cleanup or mālama ‘āina education before ocean experiences. The ideal base of operations would be Maunalua Bay because it fits the educational concept behind Kai Motion’s ocean experience model.

6. Competitive Strategy

The most appropriate strategy that Kai Motion can employ in this scenario is disruption. Kai Motion does not need to compete as one of those conventional surf schools; instead, its mission will be to move from surf lessons based on volume purchases for tourists to surf lessons that are educational and cultural and emphasize ocean stewardship as an experience. This will not just involve teaching people how to surf; rather, it will mean changing the definition of what a Hawai‘i ocean lesson entails. The alternative strategies considered, including intellectual property, architecture, and value chain, are summarized in [Appendix D](#).

Through this disruptive approach, Kai Motion will be able to break the logic that prevails within the market today. There are many surf schools that try to compete in terms of accessibility, location, prices, and teaching methods. Kai Motion competes based on meaning, responsibility, and the ability to transform its customers. Unlike other schools that treat their customers as short-term visitors for the duration of the lesson, Kai Motion sees its customers as future protectors of the ocean.

Nevertheless, Kai Motion must continue being fully responsible for the experience, because the disruptiveness is predicated on continuity. The firm cannot outsource the learning, safety, culture teaching, or stewarding processes. The unique strength that Kai Motion brings is making every step deliberate, reverent, and tied to place. In the future, Kai Motion can work with hoteliers, university

organizations, local institutions, family vacationers, and business retreat groups, but they must be partners in the Kai Motion vision.

Direct competitors are Hans Hedemann Surf School, Moniz Family Surf, Faith Surf School, Adventures in Paradise, and Aloha Beach Services. The indirect competitors for Kai Motion are snorkel tours, diving tours, fishing tours, hotels, and general tourism in Waikiki. Potential future competitors can be those that will replicate sustainability messaging through surf schools or eco-tour operators. The key to Kai Motion's sustainability is that it integrates all the following attributes into its offerings: credibility, quality control, positioning, customer emotional attachment, and stewardship-based training curriculum. A competitor summary showing Kai Motion's difference from each major competitor is included in [Appendix E](#).

7. Management Team

The roles played by Kai Motion's founders have been created in response to the fundamental requirements of the company. Kama Higa acts as the Chief Executive Officer and works with leadership, presentations, research, and projects. Nicholas Duncan is the Chief Operating Officer who assists in organizing operations, reminders, delivery, technologies, and systems. Dakota Buckley serves as Chief Financial Officer and supports financial planning, pricing, cost tracking, and social marketing. Emerson Heaton is the Chief Marketing Officer and works in market research, editing, videography, branding, and storytelling for customers.

It is also necessary to note the working norms of the team, as we are in the norming phase, currently making our way to the performing phase. This team has emphasized good communication, mutual respect, always being ahead of tasks, following one's role, and avoiding rushing at the last moment.

The primary deficiencies within the team include legal structure, liability insurance, permits, accounting, safety accreditation, culture consultation, and tourism collaboration. For these gaps to be filled, Kai Motion needs to seek out legal counsel from a business attorney, use a CPA or accountant, and establish connections with cultural consultants. These changes will increase credibility, safety, and readiness to operate within an environmentally sensitive tourism setting.

8. Financial Overview

The Kai Motion company is structured to operate on a lean basis, being a low-cost service-based company with low initial start-up, low fixed costs, and positive projected cash flows. The baseline numbers assume that there will be 260 lessons per year, consisting of 5 lessons each week for 52 weeks. If each lesson earns \$150, the total projected income for the year would amount to \$39,000. The expected annual employee salary expense is \$20,800, a fixed cost of \$3,640, and \$820 board cost in year one.¹⁰

Kai Motion does not currently need substantial external funding. The startup phase is funded by founder funds and the UH Kalo Grant. Should more funding become necessary, it will go towards covering insurance, equipment costs, marketing, partnerships, and cultural training. In this way, Kai Motion can maintain a lean strategy throughout its launch phase while developing the essential foundations to support future success.

The price strategy is value-based rather than cost-oriented. The customers will be paying for surfing lessons, ocean safety, cultural stories, small group attention, and a more responsible visitation experience. It also provides an opportunity to generate future revenue from private lessons, family packages, student packages, hotel referral services, keiki activities, and corporate retreats.

Risks associated with financing are cancellations due to the weather, seasonality, permit modifications, increased insurance premiums, lower-than-anticipated volume of bookings, and increased

¹⁰ Internal Kai Motion financial projection based on 260 lessons per year, \$150 price per lesson, \$80 employee pay per lesson, \$3,640 annual fixed costs, and \$820 in first-year board costs.

labor costs. Strategies for handling these risks include beginning operations with a small footprint, confirming demand via pilot lessons, establishing good referral sources, and measuring lessons sold, customer acquisition costs, and customer satisfaction. Detailed financial forecast data is presented in [Appendix F](#).

9. Summary

The Kai Motion venture is a solid one since it addresses a specific problem, has its target audience, identity, and a viable service-oriented business plan. The venture does not attempt to compete with any other mass-market surfing programs. It aims to become a socially responsible ocean school, which will teach tourists how to properly use Hawai'i's ocean for their pleasure.

The best parts about the business are its distinctive nature, low start-up costs, tourism foothold, cultural fit, and socially and environmentally responsible aspects. The best parts about the team are its clear-cut role definition, marine experience, marketing skills, logistical support, financial planning, and partnership-building willingness. With the right safety standards, cultural partnerships, and operating systems in place, Kai Motion is positioned to become a meaningful and financially sustainable ocean school for Hawai'i visitors. So, if you love the ocean, come to Kai Motion!

Appendices

Appendix A: Launch Timeline

Phase	Timeline	Key Activities
Phase 1: Completed Startup Setup	Completed	Registered the business, purchased insurance and permits, secured startup funding through personal funding and the UH Kalo Grant, acquired boards/equipment, and created the core service offering.
Phase 2: Early Bookings and Service Validation	Current Stage	Fulfill existing bookings, test the full Kai Motion customer experience, collect customer feedback, refine lesson flow, and confirm pricing assumptions.
Phase 3: Operating System Development	Next 1-2 Months	Finalize waivers, customer intake forms, safety checklist, lesson script, cultural education points, booking process, and customer follow-up system.
Phase 4: Marketing and Brand Growth	Next 2-3 Months	Build consistent social media content, collect photos/videos/testimonials from lessons, improve the website, and promote Kai Motion to culturally curious O‘ahu visitors.
Phase 5: Partnership Outreach	Next 3-6 Months	Begin outreach to hotels, local businesses, student organizations, tourism groups, and community partners for referrals and package opportunities.

Phase 6: Expanded Lesson Packages	6-12 Months	Add private lessons, small-group visitor packages, family sessions, and beginner-friendly ocean safety experiences.
Phase 7: Secondary Market Expansion	Year 2	Expand into UH Mānoa students, keiki programs, local beginner lessons, family packages, and corporate retreat experiences.

Appendix B: Visitor Beachhead TAM Calculation

Input	Estimate
O‘ahu visitors in 2025	5,679,047
Estimated target fit	2%
Average revenue per lesson	\$110
Estimated annual TAM	\$12,493,903

Formula: 5,679,047 visitors × 2% target fit × \$110 average revenue = approximately **\$12.49 million annual TAM**.

Appendix C: Beachhead Market Not Chosen: UH Mānoa Students

Factor	UH Mānoa Student Market
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Persona	Jordan Lee, 20-year-old UH Mānoa sophomore
Need	Beginner-friendly, affordable, culture-based ocean experience
Strengths	Accessible through campus recreation, student organizations, classes, and word of mouth
Weaknesses	More price-sensitive than tourists
Strategic role	Secondary market after visitor beachhead validation

Student TAM calculation:

20,404 UH Mānoa students × 8% likely interest × \$150 per student = approximately **\$244,848 annually**.

Appendix D: Competitive Strategies Not Chosen

Strategy	Reason Not Chosen as Main Strategy
Intellectual Property	Kai Motion may develop a branded curriculum, but the business is not mainly a patent, licensing, or legal protection model.
Architecture	Kai Motion still needs strong experience design, but architecture supports the disruption strategy rather than serving as the main strategy.

Value Chain	Partnerships with hotels, schools, and local groups are useful for growth, but they should support Kai Motion's disruptive ocean-school model rather than define the whole strategy.
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Chosen strategy: Disruption, supported by architecture and value chain partnerships.

Appendix E: Competitor Summary

Competitor	Type	Kai Motion Difference
Hans Hedemann Surf School	Direct surf school competitor	Kai Motion emphasizes small groups, cultural grounding, and stewardship
Moniz Family Surf	Direct surf school competitor	Kai Motion positions itself as an ocean school, not only a surf lesson
Faith Surf School	Direct surf school competitor	Kai Motion adds structured ocean safety and mālama 'āina education
Aloha Beach Services	Direct surf school competitor	Kai Motion differentiates through culture, place connection, and environmental responsibility
UH Recreation	Future/student competitor	Kai Motion can offer a branded, community-based ocean school model

Appendix F: Six-Year Cash Flow Projection

Year	Starting Balance	Revenue	Employee Cost	Fixed Costs	One-Time Costs	Total Costs	Net Profit	Ending Balance
1	\$0	\$39,000	\$20,800	\$3,640	\$820	\$25,260	\$13,740	\$13,740
2	\$13,740	\$39,000	\$20,800	\$3,640	\$0	\$24,440	\$14,560	\$28,300
3	\$28,300	\$39,000	\$20,800	\$3,640	\$0	\$24,440	\$14,560	\$42,860
4	\$42,860	\$39,000	\$20,800	\$3,640	\$0	\$24,440	\$14,560	\$57,420
5	\$57,420	\$39,000	\$20,800	\$3,640	\$0	\$24,440	\$14,560	\$71,980
6	\$71,980	\$39,000	\$20,800	\$3,640	\$0	\$24,440	\$14,560	\$86,540

Assumptions:

260 lessons per year, \$150 price per lesson, \$80 employee pay per lesson, \$100 monthly insurance, \$200 monthly permits, and \$820 in first-year board costs.

Appendix G: Kalo Grant



Krystal Lee

4/23/26

To: higa25@h... & 1 more



Re: Congrats! Kalo Grants Instructions

Aloha Kama,

Congratulations on your Kalo Grant. Please note that the total award amount should be \$1,200 (\$1,000 + \$200 Sustainability Round bonus).

Mahalo,
Krystal

[See More](#)



References

- Department of Business, Economic Development and Tourism. (2026, January 29). *Visitor spending increased in December 2025 as visitor arrivals declined*. <https://dbedt.hawaii.gov/blog/26-04/>
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